

Episode 143: *The Tatami Galaxy* Colour Design Notes Volume 4 (Final Volume)

The other day, the professional baseball draft was held, and promising young people were each selected by various teams. Previously, I used to think the draft "violates freedom of career choice," but recently my thinking has changed somewhat - actually, isn't it like hoping to join a big company called "Professional Baseball" and being assigned to one of 12 branch offices called "teams"? After all, these days students submit "job applications" saying "I'm going pro!"

But then how about making the "starting salary" uniform? Then from the second year onward, raises would be based on ability. What do you think?

People who don't want to go to the company called "Japanese Professional Baseball" and want to go to America, which is a "foreign company," can submit "job applications" there. Some people who have worked long-term for "Japanese Professional Baseball" might want to "change jobs" to America. Well, whether they're hired or can get the job varies.

I'm thinking about various things like this on autumn nights. ...Eh? Japan Series? What are you talking about? Incidentally, I'm a Giants fan (laugh).

Anyway.

First, let me start with the "bonus" notes.

The Tatami Galaxy was decided from the beginning to have 11 episodes for the main story, but additionally, production of a "side story" for DVD & Blu-ray bonus content equivalent to one TV-length episode was decided. It ultimately became three short films, but we in production called it "Episode 12" as work progressed. Schedule-wise, we made it immediately after working on the main story's final episode without a break. "Since it's just a 'bonus,' keep it light," said Director Yuasa. It has quite a different feel from the

main story. Incidentally, I did the colour direction myself. Three different styles, like independent films shown at school festivals - it was very interesting!

Bonus Episode 1 (Episode 12-2): Underground Submarine to Antarctica

Storyboard/Direction/Animation: Mihara Michio, Colour Direction: Tsujita Kunio

This is director Mihara-san's "solo animation" episode. All the realistic line touches for backgrounds were also drawn by Mihara-san (during the art meeting, Mihara-san had already drawn on drawing paper for backgrounds and brought them).

In the main TV series, character skin was basically colourless "white," but in this "bonus," we departed from that principle and worked freely. However, "if we stray too far, how would that be?" so we decided to minimise basic colour count and colour divisions. That's how this visual came about.

These three "bonus" episodes had colour restrictions: Natsume-san's second one was "pink" or rather "red," Miyazawa-san's third one was "black and white," and this first one by Mihara-san was "blue." Otsu appears as an octopus monster, and initially Mihara-san ordered "pinkish." A pink octopus in a blue-white world. However, when we actually placed the colour, it didn't settle well. So ultimately, the Otsu octopus also became blue. I quite like this blue Otsu octopus.

Bonus Episode 2 (Episode 12-3): Underground Submarine to Women's Bath ~Boudoir Investigation Team Pink Exploration~

Storyboard/Direction/Animation: Natsume Shingo, Colour Direction: Tsujita Kunio

This is also director Natsume-san's "solo animation." Natsume-san has completely become the "pink person" (laugh). In this episode, it's all about Akashi-san in a school

swimsuit! The way Hanuki-san's shoulder strap slips, her naked towel appearance - Natsume-san is definitely aiming for the "pink" position (laugh).

Actually, pink is quite difficult to create on PC monitors and doesn't display the way we think it should. No matter how much you raise the saturation, you can't really see the change. But when this gets shot and converted to video signal, it unexpectedly displays flashily, or the colour shifts to red or purple. But this time it was "red" rather than "pink." It worked quite well.

Like Mihara-san's, this subtly incorporates the atmosphere of "The Night Is Short, Walk on Girl." Both feature a character called "Rihaku." Plus "God of the Used Book Market" also appears.

Bonus Episode 3 (Episode 12-1): Love and Fishing Underground Submarine

Storyboard/Direction/Animation: Miyazawa Yasunori, Colour Direction: Tsujita Kunio

"Miyazawa-san is a bit of an unusual person," several people whispered to me before the meeting, but no no, he was completely normal. He was perhaps a bit single-mindedly passionate to excess (laugh), but very wonderful. This Miyazawa-san episode was actually "bonus" Episode 1, and resetting the principles we'd cultivated over 11 episodes for this meeting left me and the art staff a bit confused.

This episode is also Miyazawa-san's "solo animation." Characters are coloured, or rather colourless(?), with "white I," "black I," "white Otsu," "black Otsu"... well, something like that - a somewhat complex visual story, but since animation came up steadily in cut number order, I could do colour direction following the storyboard sequence, which was very clear and helpful.

However, one evening when we were fairly close to completion, after rushes check and retake assignments were finished and Miyazawa-san had left for home, I suddenly got a phone call from Miyazawa-san.

"Um, the colour of the harpoon, well, I'm really sorry, but I want to change it. I'm on the train right now, and I just thought of something, and then I really wanted to change it..."

"I" holds a vividly coloured harpoon in the main story, and he wanted to change the blade tip colour from light blue to reddish-black.

So from there, we spent several hours repainting all the finished cels (laugh). Actually, at that point, almost all cuts had finished colouring work. Miyazawa-san felt bad about this for a long time afterward, but no no, I was completely fine with it. Because the colour after this change fit the screen much better. Ah, amazing - Miyazawa-san's intuitive power! Another director I definitely want to work with again! (laugh)

...And that ends the "bonus" talk. Now, let's go straight to the main story until the end!

Episode 9: Secret Organisation "Lucky Cat Restaurant"

Storyboard/Direction: Yokoyama Akitoshi, Animation Director: Makihara Ryotaro,
Colour Direction: Saito Mayu

According to the original rotation, Episode 9's colour direction should have been Otsuka-san from Episodes 3 and 6, but she couldn't participate due to another project's crunch, so Saito-san joined instead. And that one episode turned out to be quite difficult (laugh).

Episode 9 is the summary story of everything up to this point. The Lucky Cat Restaurant and Otsu had been pulling strings behind all the organisations "I" had been involved with. And "I" is... The bicycle cleanup army scene where Akashi-san slaps him at

the night Incline is the present (the pre-OP too), everything before that is past recollection.

"Let's change colours by 'I's' affiliation to make it easy to understand," said Director Yuasa at the art board meeting. We'd colour-code scenes by the organisation "I" belongs to at Lucky Cat Restaurant. "Library Police" is blue-tinted, "Print Shop" is green-tinted, and "Bicycle Cleanup Army" is yellow-tinted.

When art boards came up, I created colour tones by placing characters on boards as usual and had the director & direction staff check them. Initially I thought "backgrounds in respective colours" with characters staying relatively normal throughout might work, but "ah, no, let's change everything," said the director. "Let's make characters completely monotone-ish too." I immediately remade colours on the spot and got approval from Director Yuasa and Yokoyama-san. Accordingly, we colour-changed not only new material but also bank cuts from past episodes as usual.

Since it's a summary episode, many past scenes and cuts appear dizzingly. However, there was a pleasant feeling of various fragments connecting, and while I felt sorry for Saito-san about the difficult work, I was actually quite enjoying it (laugh).

"You must not use the word 'possibility' indefinitely." "Being captivated by things that don't exist leads nowhere. Placing hope in unreliable things like your other possibilities is the root of all evil." "You must acknowledge yourself as unable to become anything other than who you are here and now." These are Master Higuchi's words at early morning Kamogawa Delta, in response to "I's" wandering and troubled questioning. I think this scene is a major pillar of this work. The gentle Kamogawa background with a slight blue tint in the black and white monotone foundation, and the blue tint of Master Higuchi's scarf created a truly transparent and beautiful screen. It's my favourite scene.

Episode 10: Four-and-a-Half-Mat-ist

Storyboard/Direction: CHOI EUNYOUNG, Animation Directors: Ito Nobutaka & Ishihama Masashi, Colour Direction: Suzuki Hisae

Episode 10 is the story of not leaving, or rather not being able to leave, the four-and-a-half-mat room. Finally the second-to-last, finally the climax.

For Episode 10, our colour team had it much easier than the art team by far. What made it so difficult? Because the enclosed four-and-a-half-mat world was to be made almost entirely with photographic backgrounds. People unfamiliar with this might think "you don't have to draw, so it's easy!" but no no, absolutely not! I may not be the one to say this, but drawing everything from scratch would be so much easier!

Actually, during production, we rented an actual four-and-a-half-mat room somewhere in Tokyo. We brought in various items (mostly Director Yuasa's personal belongings (laugh)) to construct a photography model of "I's" room. The live-action four-and-a-half-mat room that appeared in the main story, including the opening, was mostly shot here. Now, if we could have photographed that four-and-a-half-mat room exactly according to the completed storyboards and layouts, that certainly would have been easy. But in reality, that wasn't possible. We certainly had a real four-and-a-half-mat room as a model. But no matter how we tried to shoot with the camera, we could never capture exactly the angles from the storyboards. Because the layouts intentionally distorted perspective. That unique "Yuasa perspective." It's not perspective that can be created with formulas. So how did we actually create those photographic backgrounds? By cutting and pasting and combining massive amounts of reference photos.

Using the massive photo materials shot in that room, every cut was a collage storm. There were almost no cuts where a single photo could be used as-is - at most, close-ups of tatami mats. Most backgrounds used this photo as the base for this cut, this bookshelf from that photo, that wall and window from this other photo - cutting and pasting and gathering them together, transforming them in Photoshop while fitting them to the layout's distorted perspective. And drawing(!) the missing parts - truly mind-numbing work.

Meanwhile, for colours, we decided basically not to change them after being confined. However, there was a slight communication miss, or rather confirmation miss, between me and Unyoung-san. I intended to go normal, but Unyoung-san was thinking monochrome tone. Normal is very monochrome tone-ish, but actually has proper colours in it. When cels started coming up and several rushes came up, this problem was discovered. We hurriedly corrected the cels. Really, I was truly sorry > everyone involved

Episode 11 (Final Episode): The End of the Four-and-a-Half-Mat Era

Storyboard/Direction: Yuasa Masaaki, Animation Director: Ito Nobutaka, Colour Direction: Akimoto Yuki

Finally the final episode. At the series start, I first handled colour direction for Episode 1 and somehow wanted to do the final episode too, but the schedule was truly pressed, and from Episode 8 onward, episodes had almost one week from colour direction start to master delivery. Furthermore, the final episode's storyboard took until the very last minute, making it the episode with the least available time in the series. "This is impossible at my speed (cry)." I certainly wanted to do it myself, but judging from a production standpoint, it was better to have someone faster handle it. So I had Akimoto-san, who had the greatest speed among our colour direction team, handle it.

Actually, for the final episode, processing Episode 1's bank material and the massive amount of other bank material processing would all become my work, so I couldn't realistically handle it together with the main story's new cuts. Ultimately, over 1/3 of the total cuts were material cuts I processed, so well, I did 1/3 together! (laugh).

Such was final Episode 11.

"It doesn't need to connect at all, so we're changing animation for each frame, so please colourfully colour each cel," said Director Yuasa. The world seen after being released from the "four-and-a-half-mat-ist" curse was truly a world filled with colourful brilliance. We were trying to create visuals exactly like that. At this point, it was really "colour direction staff, please handle it!" and I had Akimoto-san work hard, but when I saw the results, the colourfulness was still a bit reserved. So I applied tone correction to those cels and raised the saturation dramatically with "here we go!" The correction was applied so hard that each individual colour looked like primary colours - that's how we got that screen.

Episode 11's climax was the night at Gozan that appeared in Episode 1. Actually, the script I received only went to Episode 3, and after that I only had a plot for about 9-10 episodes, so I didn't know how Episode 11 would turn out. Well, I thought "the very end will probably be in the hospital room with that line" (laugh), but I didn't know until Director's storyboard actually came up. But when I was making Episode 1, I had a vague feeling that "the final episode will probably return to this night at Gozan." And well, it was right on target!

What I was vaguely thinking during Episode 1 was "I want to properly colour these background character silhouettes in the final episode." So I put colour into each of those bank material background character silhouettes one by one. This was quite a difficult job in a good way (bitter laugh). Originally when making Episode 1, most of these background scenes were instructed as "free colouring," left to the colouring staff to paint with individual colour divisions. In Episode 1, we ultimately repainted them as single colours, but this time we recreated the colour divisions from scratch. If we had kept the very first coloured data, we could have made it somewhat easier based on that, but well, that's that. Despite having little time and being difficult, I was working quite enjoyably (laugh). And thanks to that effort, the flow from the colourful world "I" looked around at Hyakumanben intersection to the subsequent screens came together really nicely.

For Episode 11's scene colour changes, what the director and I refined until the very end was that summer recollection scene of the used book festival at Shimogamo Shrine

grounds. The major axis of *The Tatami Galaxy* is "I" and Otsu, but another axis is definitely "I" and Akashi-san.

"Green" for this scene was decided from the art board meeting, so how should we build it accordingly? In this recollection, for the first time in the series, "I" confesses that he "fell for Akashi-san." So I wanted to make this scene the best scene in Episode 11.

The best scene for "I" and Akashi-san is that Episode 1 evening recollection scene in Tadasu Forest. So naturally, both the director and I headed in that direction. Built like when we created the colours for that evening recollection scene, that's how we arrived at those colours for that scene.

...And with that, we've finished all episodes including "bonus" (applause).

This is self-praise, but this isn't just my work - it's very good work that we all in the colour team accomplished together with all the colour direction staff who worked hard with me. This colour team was truly a dream team for me. And I'm truly grateful to everyone for being able to work with the wonderful, or rather amazing staff including Director Yuasa. They were truly enjoyable days. A wonderful experience from late autumn 2009 to early summer 2010. And I hope that someday, somehow, all of us can meet again somewhere.

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